

CHRISTIANITY



CHRISTIANS BELIEVE that Jesus of Nazareth was the son of God, who came to Earth as promised in the Old Testament, and through whose life, death, and resurrection believers are freed from their sinful state. Christianity began in the first century AD in the area now known as Israel and Palestine, which was then a part of the Roman empire. The faith was gradually spread around the Mediterranean by followers of Christ, such as Saint Paul.

Christian world

In the early years there were few Christians, and they were persecuted by the Romans because they refused to worship the Roman gods. But in AD 394, Christianity became the official religion of the Roman empire after the conversion of the emperor Constantine. The faith spread quickly through the empire. Today's Catholic Church is still based in Rome and claims to be the descendant of the early Church in the Mediterranean. There are now nearly 1.6 billion Christians worldwide.

Shading shows worldwide distribution of Christians.



Christianity is the largest world religion.



Medieval censer



In Catholic churches, incense is burnt to release scented smoke.



Charcoal is put into the censer and lit to heat the incense.

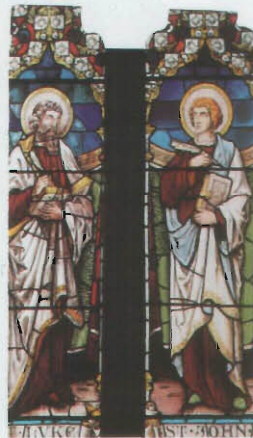


The cross symbolizes Christ's resurrection from the dead.

This elaborate gold cross is ornamented with precious stones.

Cross

Christ's death on the cross, and his resurrection, were the two key events in his life on Earth. The cross has therefore become the most important Christian symbol. Every church is marked by a cross, and crosses are placed on altars and in other prominent places inside. During worship, some Christians make the sign of the cross.



Stained glass window showing St. Luke and St. John teaching the gospel.

Spreading the word

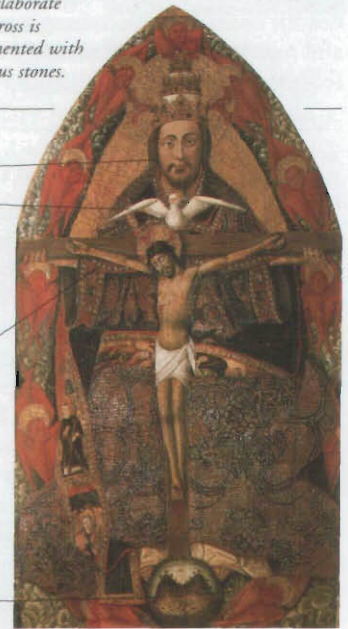
Jesus preached the coming of God's kingdom, but his message was rejected and he was put to death. On the third day after Christ's death, God brought him back to life. Christ met his followers and told them to spread the word. Since then, Christianity has been spread by preachers and missionaries. From Europe, colonists took the faith with them to Africa, the Americas, and Australasia.

God the Father

The Holy Spirit is shown as a white dove, the symbol of peace.

Christ on the cross is a symbol of death and salvation.

Beneath Christ's feet is a globe representing the Earth.



Holy Trinity

Christians believe that God exists as three persons: God the Father is the creator; God the Son is Jesus Christ; and God the Holy Spirit is the presence of God on Earth. It is the Holy Spirit that inspires prophets and that acts as a means of divine revelation. Although there are three persons in the Holy Trinity, they exist as one substance, so Christians believe in one God.

Branches of Christianity

Two important groups have split from the Roman Catholic Church: the Protestant Churches, which broke away during the Reformation of the 16th century; and the Eastern Orthodox Church, which is strong in eastern Europe and western Asia.

Roman Catholicism

Catholics make up the largest Christian denomination. They stress the importance of the Church's role in interpreting the scriptures and the authority of the Pope as the leader of the Church. They believe in the doctrine of transubstantiation, in other words that the bread and wine used in the Mass are actually converted into the body and blood of Christ.



A Protestant service in London, UK

Bare walls without paintings or statues

Protestantism

There are many different Protestant Churches based around the world, but especially in North America. To a greater or lesser extent, they all stress the authority of scripture itself, rather than the clergy's interpretation of the text of the Bible. They do not believe in the doctrine of transubstantiation. Although there is great variation in their rituals, Protestants have simpler church buildings and less elaborate ceremonies than the Catholic and Orthodox Churches.



Orthodox Christians pray to icons, such as this image of St. George.

Orthodoxy

Like the Roman Church, the Eastern Orthodox Church stresses the importance of the sacraments. Orthodox Christians do not recognize the authority of the Pope: the highest authority is the Church's Ecumenical Council.